

Tianlu Zhang

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SUMMARY

- Human factors researcher with 5+ year designing rigorous user studies across tech product and academic contexts.
- Proven track record translating complex attitudinal and behavioral data into product decisions at scale.
- Rich experience in communicating with academic and industrial partners and collaborating cross-functionally.

EDUCATION

The University of Texas at Austin

Ph.D. in Developmental Psychology | M.S. in Statistics

Coursework: Mathematical Statistics, Regression Analyses, Causal Inference, Scientific Machine Learning

Austin, TX, USA

expected 04/2028

Renmin University of China

M.A., Social Psychology

Beijing, China

06/2022

Sun Yat-Sen University

B.A., Communication

Guangzhou, China

06/2019

EXPERIENCE

Tencent

UX Researcher

06/2021 - 06/2023

Shenzhen, China

- Delivered end-to-end **quantitative** and **qualitative research** support across 2 product teams in a fast-paced environment, managing stakeholders with competing priorities to align research insights with product decisions.
- Led **10+ mixed-methods research projects** for Mobile QQ and QQ Metaverse; translating findings into design specifications and product strategy that informed feature development and design iteration.
- Diagnosed critical loading failures in the QQ Metaverse **AI render engine** by triangulating user **survey data with behavioral traces**; findings informed the decision to integrate the engine and shaped its deployment strategy.
- Evaluated user perceptions and acceptance of the **AIGC avatar** feature through **in-depth interviews**, identifying design integration strategies that balance user experience and design productivity.
- Designed and validated custom **satisfaction measurement instruments** from scratch for each QQ Metaverse release cycle, iterating question design to capture user perceptions with validity and sensitivity across feature launches.
- Diagnosed **70% user inactivity** in QQ Metaverse by designing a **comparative survey study** across active and inactive user segments, resulting feature exposure strategy were adopted by the product team and shipped.
- Supported an **in-person usability test** for a mobile game prototype, observing real-time user behavior to identify pain points; facilitated a follow-up **focus group** to synthesize user suggestions and inform design iteration.

The University of Texas at Austin

Graduate Research Assistant

08/2023 - Present

Austin, TX, USA

- Designed and scoped longitudinal research studies integrating **self-reported survey**, **biological**, and **behavioral data** to examine how contextual stress and family impact youths' physiological and mental health.
- Conducted exploratory/confirmatory factor analyses, built **regression/time series/machine learning models** (Random Forest/XGBoost), translated findings through peer-reviewed publications (8 published; 4 under review).
- Built **automated R pipelines** for longitudinal data cleaning, transformation, outlier detection, and biomarker computation, enabling scalable, reproducible processing of high-volume behavioral datasets.
- Contributed to two national-level grant applications, drafting research aims and methodology, conducting power analyses for **sample size planning**.
- Coordinated 5+ ongoing projects and mentored 2 undergraduate students; served on the departmental **statistics committee** and led two years of workshops on **power analysis** and **data visualization in R**.

Austin Water

Data Science Intern

05/2025 - 08/2025

Austin, TX, USA

- Scoped and led an end-to-end research project to establish water use benchmarks for student housing, defining research objectives, breaking down project phases, and aligning stakeholders across teams on a feasible plan.
- Applied DBSCAN clustering to 8 years of water usage data from 10 properties, uncovering distinct consumption profiles across housing types; Presented findings to stakeholders, leading 8 additional properties to join the project.

SKILLS

UX Research Methods: survey instrument design, usability testing, semi-structured interviews, diary studies, concept testing, card sorting, psychometric scale development, longitudinal research design, mixed-methods research, sampling design

Research & UX Tools: Qualtrics, UserTesting, UserZoom (*familiar*)

Statistical Techniques: (M)ANOVA, Regression, GLM, Time series, Survival analyses, Structural equation modeling, A/B testing & experimental design, Machine Learning models (Decision Trees/Random Forests/XGboost/Clustering/PCA)

Software: SQL, R (tidyverse/bruceR/ggplot2/caret), Python (NumPy/Pandas/Matplotlib/sklearn), Tableau